convince cattle owners to opt for breed improvement." The results are already showing. Between FY25 and FY26, the number of artificial insemination procedures increased from around 1.25 million to 2.09 million, while the number of animals on whom the procedure was performed rose from 1.08 million to 1.68 million.

However, the problem with artificial insemination is that even with documentation, it can take up to 20 years and six generations to produce a pure-bred animal. IVF shortens this timeline. "A 100 per cent pure-bred embryo implanted in an animal can yield a pure-bred offspring in a single generation," says Dr Anand Kushwaha, in charge of the IVF lab at Bhopal's Bull Mother Farm, which has produced 450 offspring.

Promotion of quality feed is another critical area. Good feed means an animal comes into heat at around 1.5 years, compared to three years in its absence, affecting productivity. An app guides farmers on the right green fodder to enhance milk production. In MP, green fodder is sown over a mere 29,000 hectares, compared to 1.7 million hectares in Gujarat, which is widely regarded as a model for success in the dairy sector. The animal husbandry, forest and agriculture departments in MP are working together to promote green fodder cultivation.

While the state's potential is immense, challenges remain. For one, there seems to have been no fresh recruitment of veterinarians, with reliance on contract AVFOs and private hires. Equipment used for artificial insemination and IVF is largely imported, slowing servicing and repairs. Budgetary support, though higher, remains inadequate.

Takeaways

- **Upgrading quality: boosting better breeds via artificial insemination, IVF to up yields**
- **Aiming to more than double MP's milk production in five years and raise its share of India's dairy output from 9% to 20%**
- **Promoting quality feed, sowing green fodder**
- **Giving cooperatives to NDDB; raising procurement, farmer participation**

COOP REVAMP

MP embarked on its white revolution journey in April 2025, when it signed an MoU with the National Dairy Development Board (NDDB), handing over management control of the MP State Cooperative Dairy Federation (MPSCDF). Since then, the NDDB has focused on boosting milk collection and diversifying products to drive demand. The number of villages with collection points has risen from 5,763 to 6,989, lifting daily procurement from 950,000 litres to 1.15 million litres. "Our target is to expand to about 26,000 villages—half the state—and raise collection to five million litres a day in five years," says Sanjay Govani, MD, MPSCDF. The dairy farmer membership base has also grown from 214,000 to 250,000 in a year. Payment to dairy farmers supplying milk to the federation has been increased by Rs 2 to Rs 8.5 per litre.

The role of cooperatives in boosting dairy incomes is critical: Gujarat channels 90 per cent of its milk procurement through cooperatives, while MP manages only 4 per cent—making a clear case for strengthening the MP milk cooperative union.

Ultimately, though, results—not rhetoric—will matter. ■

INTERVIEW | MOHAN YADAV

"More milk will help tackle malnutrition among children"

The Madhya Pradesh chief minister speaks to INDIA TODAY *on his plans to develop MP's dairy sector. Excerpts:*

Q. You have announced that milk production will be doubled. How do you plan to achieve this?

A. When we handed over the state's milk cooperative to the National Dairy Development Board last year, daily milk collection stood at 9.55 lakh litres and has now increased to 11.72 lakh litres per day. We plan to take the same model forward to eventually reach 50 lakh litres per day. The state's milk production is much higher, at around 5.5 crore litres per day, which is why there is tremendous potential in this sector.

Q. Many BJP-run states focus on the *gaushala* model to protect cows. Your approach seems more rooted in economics.

A. We cannot be dependent only on charity and religion for the protection of cows; we must become self-sufficient. There is a focus on breed improvement, proper and nutritious diets for cattle and the modernisation of processing units. One eye has to be on the market. We are also concerned about the marginal farmer, who can raise his income.

Q. It is said that your focus on the dairy sector is aimed at strengthening your political position, as you hail from a community engaged in rearing cattle.

A. Who is a *gopal*? Anyone who has a cow is a *gopal*. All communities engaged in agriculture also keep cattle and earn from them. Any community involved in milk production, regardless of caste or religion, will benefit from the development of the sector. Milk would also help tackle malnutrition. ■

For the full interview, please log on to indiatoday.in/magazine